1 Corinthians

Chapters

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12 13 14 15 16

THE FIRST LETTER OF PAUL TO THE CORINTHIANS

Salutation

1 Paul, called by the will of God to be an apostle of Christ Jesus, and our
brother Sos'thenes,
2 To the Church of God which is at Corinth, to those sanctified in Christ
Jesus, called to be saints * together with all those who in every place call on
the name of our Lord Jesus Christ, both their Lord and ours:
3 Grace to you and peace from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ.

4 I give thanks to God[a] always for you because of the grace of God which
was given you in Christ Jesus, 5that in every way you were enriched in him
with all speech and all knowledge—6even as the testimony to Christ was
confirmed among you—7so that you are not lacking in any spiritual gift, as
you wait for the revealing of our Lord Jesus Christ; 8who will sustain you to
the end, guiltless in the day of our Lord Jesus Christ. 9God is faithful, by
whom you were called into the fellowship of his Son, Jesus Christ our Lord.

Dissension in the Church

10 I appeal to you, brethren, by the name of our Lord Jesus Christ, that all
of you agree and that there be no dissensions among you, but that you be
united in the same mind and the same judgment. 11For it has been reported
to me by Chlo'e's people that there is quarreling among you, my brethren.
12What I mean is that each one of you says, "I belong to Paul," or "I belong
to Apol'los," or "I belong to Ce'phas," * or "I belong to Christ." 13Is Christ
divided? Was Paul crucified for you? Or were you baptized in the name of
Paul? 14I am thankful[b] that I baptized none of you except Crispus and
Ga'ius; 15lest any one should say that you were baptized in my name. 16(I
did baptize also the household of Steph'anas. Beyond that, I do not know
whether I baptized any one else.) 17For Christ did not send me to baptize
but to preach the gospel, and not with eloquent wisdom, lest the cross of
Christ be emptied of its power.

Christ the Power and Wisdom of God

18 For the word of the cross is folly to those who are perishing, but to us
who are being saved it is the power of God. 19For it is written,

"I will destroy the wisdom of the wise,
and the cleverness of the clever I will thwart."

20 Where is the wise man? Where is the scribe? Where is the debater of
this age? Has not God made foolish the wisdom of the world? 21 For since,
in the wisdom of God, the world did not know God through wisdom, it
pleased God through the folly of what we preach to save those who believe.
22 For Jews demand signs and Greeks seek wisdom, 23 but we preach Christ
crucified, a stumbling block to Jews and folly to Gentiles, 24 but to those
who are called, both Jews and Greeks, Christ the power of God and the
wisdom of God. 25 For the foolishness of God is wiser than men, and the
weakness of God is stronger than men.

26 For consider your call, brethren; not many of you were wise according
to the flesh, not many were powerful, not many were of noble birth; 27 but
God chose what is foolish in the world to shame the wise, God chose what
is weak in the world to shame the strong, 28 God chose what is low and
despised in the world, even things that are not, to bring to nothing things
that are, 29 so that no flesh might boast in the presence of God. 30 He is the
source of your life in Christ Jesus, whom God made our wisdom, our
righteousness and sanctification and redemption; 31 therefore, as it is
written, "Let him who boasts, boast of the Lord."

Proclaiming Christ Crucified

2 When I came to you, brethren, I did not come proclaiming to you the
testimony[c] of God in lofty words or wisdom. 2 For I decided to know
nothing among you except Jesus Christ and him crucified. * 3 And I was
with you in weakness and in much fear and trembling; 4 and my speech and
my message were not in plausible words of wisdom, but in demonstration
of the Spirit and of power, 5 that your faith might not rest in the wisdom of
men but in the power of God.

The True Wisdom of God

6 Yet among the mature we do impart wisdom, although it is not a wisdom
of this age or of the rulers of this age, who are doomed to pass away. 7 But
we impart a secret and hidden wisdom of God, which God decreed before
the ages for our glorification. 8 None of the rulers of this age understood
this; for if they had, they would not have crucified the Lord of glory. 9 But,
as it is written,

> "What no eye has seen, nor ear heard,
> nor the heart of man conceived,

what God has prepared for those who love him,”
10 God has revealed to us through the Spirit. For the Spirit searches
everything, even the depths of God. 11 For what person knows a man’s
thoughts except the spirit of the man which is in him? So also no one
comprehends the thoughts of God except the Spirit of God. 12 Now we have
received not the spirit of the world, but the Spirit which is from God, that
we might understand the gifts bestowed on us by God. 13 And we impart this
in words not taught by human wisdom but taught by the Spirit, interpreting
spiritual truths to those who possess the Spirit.[d]
14 The unspiritual[e] man does not receive the gifts of the Spirit of God, for
they are folly to him, and he is not able to understand them because they are
spiritually discerned. 15 The spiritual man judges all things, but is himself to
be judged by no one. 16 “For who has known the mind of the Lord so as to
instruct him?” But we have the mind of Christ.

On Dissension in the Corinthian Church

3 But I, brethren, could not address you as spiritual men, but as men of
the flesh, as infants in Christ. 2 I fed you with milk, not solid food; for you
were not ready for it; and even yet you are not ready, 3 for you are still of the
flesh. For while there is jealousy and strife among you, are you not of the
flesh, and behaving like ordinary men? 4 For when one says, “I belong to
Paul,” and another, “I belong to Apol'los,” are you not merely men?
5 What then is Apol'los? What is Paul? Servants through whom you
believed, as the Lord assigned to each. 6 I planted, Apol'los watered, but
God gave the growth. 7 So neither he who plants nor he who waters is
anything, but only God who gives the growth. 8 He who plants and he who
waters are equal, and each shall receive his wages according to his labor.
9 For we are God’s fellow workers;[f] you are God’s field, God’s building.
10 According to the commission of God given to me, like a skilled master
builder I laid a foundation, and another man is building upon it. Let each
man take care how he builds upon it. 11 For no other foundation can any one
lay than that which is laid, which is Jesus Christ. 12 Now if any one builds
on the foundation with gold, silver, precious stones, wood, hay, straw—
13 each man’s work will become manifest; for the Day * will disclose it,
because it will be revealed with fire, and the fire will test what sort of work
each one has done. 14 If the work which any man has built on the foundation

survives, he will receive a reward. [15]If any man's work is burned up, he will suffer loss, though he himself will be saved, but only as through fire.

16 Do you not know that you are God's temple * and that God's Spirit dwells in you? [17]If any one destroys God's temple, God will destroy him. For God's temple is holy, and that temple you are.

18 Let no one deceive himself. If any one among you thinks that he is wise in this age, let him become a fool that he may become wise. [19]For the wisdom of this world is folly with God. For it is written, "He catches the wise in their craftiness," [20]and again, "The Lord knows that the thoughts of the wise are futile." [21]So let no one boast of men. For all things are yours, [22]whether Paul or Apol'los or Ce'phas or the world or life or death or the present or the future, all are yours; [23]and you are Christ's; and Christ is God's.

The Ministry of the Apostles

4 This is how one should regard us, as servants of Christ and stewards of the mysteries of God. [2]Moreover it is required of stewards that they be found trustworthy. [3]But with me it is a very small thing that I should be judged by you or by any human court. I do not even judge myself. [4]I am not aware of anything against myself, but I am not thereby acquitted. It is the Lord who judges me. [5]Therefore do not pronounce judgment before the time, before the Lord comes, who will bring to light the things now hidden in darkness and will disclose the purposes of the heart. Then every man will receive his commendation from God.

6 I have applied all this to myself and Apol'los for your benefit, brethren, that you may learn by us not to go beyond what is written, that none of you may be puffed up in favor of one against another. [7]For who sees anything different in you? What have you that you did not receive? If then you received it, why do you boast as if it were not a gift?

8 Already you are filled! Already you have become rich! Without us you have become kings! And would that you did reign, so that we might share the rule with you! [9]For I think that God has exhibited us apostles as last of all, like men sentenced to death; because we have become a spectacle to the world, to angels and to men. [10]We are fools for Christ's sake, but you are wise in Christ. We are weak, but you are strong. You are held in honor, but we in disrepute. [11]To the present hour we hunger and thirst, we are poorly

clothed and buffeted and homeless, [12]and we labor, working with our own hands. When reviled, we bless; when persecuted, we endure; [13]when slandered, we try to conciliate; we have become, and are now, as the refuse of the world, the dregs of all things.

Fatherly Admonition

14 I do not write this to make you ashamed, but to admonish you as my beloved children. [15]For though you have countless guides in Christ, you do not have many fathers. For I became your father in Christ Jesus through the gospel. [16]I urge you, then, be imitators of me. [17]Therefore I sent[g] to you Timothy, my beloved and faithful child in the Lord, to remind you of my ways in Christ, as I teach them everywhere in every church. [18]Some are arrogant, as though I were not coming to you. [19]But I will come to you soon, if the Lord wills, and I will find out not the talk of these arrogant people but their power. [20]For the kingdom of God does not consist in talk but in power. [21]What do you wish? Shall I come to you with a rod, or with love in a spirit of gentleness?

Sexual Immorality Defiles the Church

5 It is actually reported that there is immorality among you, and of a kind that is not found even among pagans; for a man is living with his father's wife. * [2]And you are arrogant! Ought you not rather to mourn? Let him who has done this be removed from among you.

3 For though absent in body I am present in spirit, and as if present, I have already pronounced judgment [4]in the name of the Lord Jesus on the man who has done such a thing. When you are assembled, and my spirit is present, with the power of our Lord Jesus, [5]you are to deliver this man to Satan * for the destruction of the flesh, that his spirit may be saved in the day of the Lord Jesus.[h]

6 Your boasting is not good. Do you not know that a little leaven leavens all the dough? [7]Cleanse out the old leaven that you may be new dough, as you really are unleavened. For Christ, our Paschal Lamb, has been sacrificed. [8]Let us, therefore, celebrate the festival, not with the old leaven, the leaven of malice and evil, but with the unleavened bread of sincerity and truth.

Immorality and Judgment

9 I wrote to you in my letter not to associate with immoral men; * 10not at
all meaning the immoral * of this world, or the greedy and robbers, or
idolaters, since then you would need to go out of the world. 11But rather I
wrote[i] to you not to associate with any one who bears the name of brother if
he is guilty of immorality § or greed, or is an idolater, reviler, drunkard, or
robber—not even to eat with such a one. 12For what have I to do with
judging outsiders? Is it not those inside the Church whom you are to judge?
13God judges those outside. " Drive out the wicked person from among
you."

Lawsuits among Believers

6 When one of you has a grievance against a brother, does he dare go to
law before the unrighteous * instead of the saints? 2Do you not know that
the saints will judge the world? And if the world is to be judged by you, are
you incompetent to try trivial cases? 3Do you not know that we are to judge
angels? How much more, matters pertaining to this life! 4If then you have
such cases, why do you lay them before those who are least esteemed by the
Church? 5I say this to your shame. Can it be that there is no man among you
wise enough to decide between members of the brotherhood, 6but brother
goes to law against brother, and that before unbelievers?
7 To have lawsuits at all with one another is defeat for you. Why not
rather suffer wrong? Why not rather be defrauded? 8But you yourselves
wrong and defraud, and that even your own brethren.
9 Do you not know that the unrighteous will not inherit the kingdom of
God? Do not be deceived; neither the immoral, * nor idolaters, nor
adulterers, nor homosexuals,[j] * 10nor thieves, nor the greedy, nor drunkards,
nor revilers, nor robbers will inherit the kingdom of God. 11And such were
some of you. But you were washed, you were sanctified, you were justified
in the name of the Lord Jesus Christ and in the Spirit of our God.

Glorifying God in the Body

12 "All things are lawful for me," but not all things are helpful. "All
things are lawful for me," § but I will not be enslaved by anything. 13"Food
is meant for the stomach and the stomach for food"—and God will destroy
both one and the other. The body is not meant for immorality, * but for the
Lord, and the Lord for the body. 14And God raised the Lord and will also
raise us up by his power. 15Do you not know that your bodies are members

of Christ? Shall I therefore take the members of Christ and make them members of a prostitute? Never! 16Do you not know that he who joins himself to a prostitute becomes one body with her? For, as it is written, “The two shall become one.”k 17But he who is united to the Lord becomes one spirit with him. 18Shun immorality. * Every other sin which a man commits is outside the body; but the immoral man sins against his own body. 19Do you not know that your body is a temple of the Holy Spirit within you, which you have from God? You are not your own; 20you were bought with a price. So glorify God in your body.

Concerning Marriage

7 Now concerning the matters about which you wrote. It is well for a man not to touch a woman. 2But because of the temptation to immorality, each man should have his own wife and each woman her own husband. * 3The husband should give to his wife her conjugal rights, and likewise the wife to her husband. 4For the wife does not rule over her own body, but the husband does; likewise the husband does not rule over his own body, but the wife does. 5Do not refuse one another except perhaps by agreement for a season, that you may devote yourselves to prayer; but then come together again, lest Satan tempt you through lack of self-control. 6I say this by way of concession, not of command. 7I wish that all were as I myself am. But each has his own special gift from God, one of one kind and one of another.

8 To the unmarried and the widows I say that it is well for them to remain single as I do. 9But if they cannot exercise self-control, they should marry. For it is better to marry than to be aflame with passion.

10 To the married I give charge, not I but the Lord, that the wife should not separate from her husband 11(but if she does, let her remain single or else be reconciled to her husband)—and that the husband should not divorce his wife.

12 To the rest I say, not the Lord, that if any brother has a wife who is an unbeliever, and she consents to live with him, he should not divorce her. 13If any woman has a husband who is an unbeliever, and he consents to live with her, she should not divorce him. 14For the unbelieving husband is consecrated through his wife, and the unbelieving wife is consecrated through her husband. Otherwise, your children would be unclean, but as it is they are holy. 15But if the unbelieving partner desires to separate, let it be

so; in such a case the brother or sister is not bound. For God has called us[l] to peace. 16Wife, how do you know whether you will save your husband? Husband, how do you know whether you will save your wife?

Leading the Life the Lord Has Assigned

17 Only, let every one lead the life which the Lord has assigned to him, and in which God has called him. This is my rule in all the churches. 18Was any one at the time of his call already circumcised? Let him not seek to remove the marks of circumcision. Was any one at the time of his call uncircumcised? Let him not seek circumcision. 19For neither circumcision counts for anything nor uncircumcision, but keeping the commandments of God. 20Every one should remain in the state in which he was called. 21Were you a slave when called? Never mind. But if you can gain your freedom, avail yourself of the opportunity.[x] 22For he who was called in the Lord as a slave is a freedman of the Lord. Likewise he who was free when called is a slave of Christ. 23You were bought with a price; do not become slaves of men. 24So, brethren, in whatever state each was called, there let him remain with God.

More concerning Marriage

25 Now concerning the unmarried,[x2] I have no command of the Lord, but I give my opinion as one who by the Lord's mercy is trustworthy. 26I think that in view of the impending distress[m] it is well for a person to remain as he is. 27Are you bound to a wife? Do not seek to be free. Are you free from a wife? Do not seek marriage. 28But if you marry, you do not sin, and if a girl [m2] marries she does not sin. Yet those who marry will have worldly troubles, and I would spare you that. 29I mean, brethren, the appointed time has grown very short; from now on, let those who have wives live as though they had none, 30and those who mourn as though they were not mourning, and those who rejoice as though they were not rejoicing, and those who buy as though they had no goods, 31and those who deal with the world as though they had no dealings with it. For the form of this world is passing away.

32 I want you to be free from anxieties. The unmarried man is anxious about the affairs of the Lord, how to please the Lord; 33but the married man is anxious about worldly affairs, how to please his wife, 34and his interests are divided. And the unmarried woman or virgin is anxious about the affairs

of the Lord, how to be holy in body and spirit; but the married woman is anxious about worldly affairs, how to please her husband. 35I say this for your own benefit, not to lay any restraint upon you, but to promote good order and to secure your undivided devotion to the Lord.

36 If any one thinks that he is not behaving properly toward his betrothed,[m2] if his passions are strong, and it has to be, let him do as he wishes: let them marry—it is no sin. 37But whoever is firmly established in his heart, being under no necessity but having his desire under control, and has determined this in his heart, to keep her as his betrothed,[m2] he will do well. 38So that he who marries his betrothed[m2] does well; and he who refrains from marriage will do better.

39 A wife is bound to her husband as long as he lives. If the husband dies, she is free to be married to whom she wishes, only in the Lord. 40But in my judgment she is happier if she remains as she is. And I think that I have the Spirit of God.

Food Offered to Idols

8 Now concerning food offered to idols: * we know that "all of us possess knowledge." "Knowledge" puffs up, but love builds up. 2If any one imagines that he knows something, he does not yet know as he ought to know. 3But if one loves God, one is known by him.

4 Hence, as to the eating of food offered to idols, we know that "an idol has no real existence," and that "there is no God but one." 5For although there may be so-called gods in heaven or on earth—as indeed there are many "gods" and many "lords"—6yet for us there is one God, the Father, from whom are all things and for whom we exist, and one Lord, Jesus Christ, through whom are all things and through whom we exist.

7 However, not all possess this knowledge. But some, through being until now accustomed to idols, eat food as really offered to an idol; and their conscience, being weak, is defiled. 8Food will not commend us to God. We are no worse off if we do not eat, and no better off if we do. 9Only take care lest this liberty of yours somehow become a stumbling block to the weak. 10For if any one sees you, a man of knowledge, at table in an idol's temple, might he not be encouraged, if his conscience is weak, to eat food offered to idols? 11And so by your knowledge this weak man is destroyed, the brother for whom Christ died. 12Thus, sinning against your brethren and wounding

their conscience when it is weak, you sin against Christ. 13Therefore, if food is a cause of my brother's falling, I will never eat meat, lest I cause my brother to fall.

The Rights of an Apostle

9 Am I not free? Am I not an apostle? Have I not seen Jesus our Lord? Are you not my workmanship in the Lord? 2If to others I am not an apostle, at least I am to you; for you are the seal of my apostleship in the Lord.

3 This is my defense to those who would examine me. * 4Do we not have the right to our food and drink? 5Do we not have the right to be accompanied by a wife,[n] * as the other apostles and the brethren * of the Lord and Cephas? 6Or is it only Barnabas and I who have no right to refrain from working for a living? 7Who serves as a soldier at his own expense? Who plants a vineyard without eating any of its fruit? Who tends a flock without getting some of the milk?

8 Do I say this on human authority? Does not the law say the same? 9For it is written in the law of Moses, "You shall not muzzle an ox when it is treading out the grain." Is it for oxen that God is concerned? 10Does he not speak entirely for our sake? It was written for our sake, because the plowman should plow in hope and the thresher thresh in hope of a share in the crop. 11If we have sown spiritual good among you, is it too much if we reap your material benefits? 12If others share this rightful claim upon you, do not we still more?

Nevertheless, we have not made use of this right, but we endure anything rather than put an obstacle in the way of the gospel of Christ. 13Do you not know that those who are employed in the temple service get their food from the temple, and those who serve at the altar share in the sacrificial offerings? 14In the same way, the Lord commanded that those who proclaim the gospel should get their living by the gospel.

15 But I have made no use of any of these rights, nor am I writing this to secure any such provision. For I would rather die than have any one deprive me of my ground for boasting. 16For if I preach the gospel, that gives me no ground for boasting. For necessity is laid upon me. Woe to me if I do not preach the gospel! 17For if I do this of my own will, I have a reward; but if not of my own will, I am entrusted with a commission. 18What then is my

reward? Just this: that in my preaching I may make the gospel free of charge, not making full use of my right in the gospel.

The Responsibilities of the Apostle

19 For though I am free from all men, I have made myself a slave to all,
that I might win the more. [20]To the Jews I became as a Jew, in order to win
Jews; to those under the law I became as one under the law—though not
being myself under the law—that I might win those under the law. [21]To
those outside the law I became as one outside the law—not being without
law toward God but under the law of Christ—that I might win those outside
the law. [22]To the weak I became weak, that I might win the weak. I have
become all things to all men, that I might by all means save some. [23]I do it
all for the sake of the gospel, that I may share in its blessings.

24 Do you not know that in a race all the runners compete, but only one
receives the prize? So run that you may obtain it. [25]Every athlete exercises
self-control in all things. They do it to receive a perishable wreath, but we
an imperishable. [26]Well, I do not run aimlessly, I do not box as one beating
the air; [27]but I pommel my body and subdue it, lest after preaching to others
I myself should be disqualified.

Warnings from Israel's History

10 I want you to know, brethren, that our fathers were all under the
cloud, and all passed through the sea, [2]and all were baptized into Moses in
the cloud and in the sea, [3]and all ate the same supernatural[o] food [4]and all
drank the same supernatural[o] drink. For they drank from the supernatural[o]
Rock which followed them, and the Rock was Christ. [5]Nevertheless with
most of them God was not pleased; for they were overthrown in the
wilderness.

6 Now these things are warnings for us, not to desire evil as they did. [7]Do
not be idolaters as some of them were; as it is written, "The people sat
down to eat and drink and rose up to dance." [8]We must not indulge in
immorality as some of them did, and twenty-three thousand fell in a single
day. [9]We must not put the Lord[p] to the test, as some of them did and were
destroyed by serpents; [10]nor grumble, as some of them did and were
destroyed by the Destroyer. [11]Now these things happened to them as a
warning, but they were written down for our instruction, upon whom the
end of the ages has come. [12]Therefore let any one who thinks that he stands

take heed lest he fall. 13 No temptation has overtaken you that is not
common to man. God is faithful, and he will not let you be tempted beyond
your strength, but with the temptation will also provide the way of escape,
that you may be able to endure it.

14 Therefore, my beloved, shun the worship of idols. 15 I speak as to
sensible men; judge for yourselves what I say. 16 The cup of blessing which
we bless, is it not a participation[q] in the blood of Christ? The bread which
we break, is it not a participation[q] in the body of Christ? 17 Because there is
one bread, we who are many are one body, for we all partake of the one
bread. 18 Consider the people of Israel; are not those who eat the sacrifices
partners in the altar? 19 What do I imply then? That food offered to idols is
anything, or that an idol is anything? 20 No, I imply that what pagans
sacrifice they offer to demons and not to God. I do not want you to be
partners with demons. * 21 You cannot drink the cup of the Lord and the cup
of demons. You cannot partake of the table of the Lord and the table of
demons. 22 Shall we provoke the Lord to jealousy? Are we stronger than he?

All to the Glory of God

23 "All things are lawful," but not all things are helpful. "All things are
lawful," but not all things build up. 24 Let no one seek his own good, but the
good of his neighbor. 25 Eat whatever is sold in the meat market without
raising any question on the ground of conscience. 26 For "the earth is the
Lord's, and everything in it." 27 If one of the unbelievers invites you to
dinner and you are disposed to go, eat whatever is set before you without
raising any question on the ground of conscience. 28 (But if some one says to
you, "This has been offered in sacrifice," then out of consideration for the
man who informed you, and for conscience' sake— 29 I mean his conscience,
not yours—do not eat it.) For why should my liberty be determined by
another man's scruples? 30 If I partake with thankfulness, why am I
denounced because of that for which I give thanks?

31 So, whether you eat or drink, or whatever you do, do all to the glory of
God. 32 Give no offense to Jews or to Greeks or to the Church of God, 33 just
as I try to please all men in everything I do, not seeking my own advantage,
but that of

11 many, that they may be saved. 1 Be imitators of me, as I am of Christ.

Head Coverings

2 I commend you because you remember me in everything and maintain
the traditions even as I have delivered them to you. 3But I want you to
understand that the head of every man is Christ, the head of a woman is her
husband, and the head of Christ is God. 4Any man who prays or prophesies
with his head covered dishonors his head, 5but any woman who prays or
prophesies with her head unveiled dishonors her head—it is the same as if
her head were shaven. 6For if a woman will not veil herself, then she should
cut off her hair; but if it is disgraceful for a woman to be shorn or shaven,
let her wear a veil. 7For a man ought not to cover his head, since he is the
image and glory of God; but woman is the glory of man. 8(For man was not
made from woman, but woman from man. 9Neither was man created for
woman, but woman for man.) 10That is why a woman ought to have a veil[r]
on her head, because of the angels. 11(Nevertheless, in the Lord woman is
not independent of man nor man of woman; 12for as woman was made from
man, so man is now born of woman. And all things are from God.) 13Judge
for yourselves; is it proper for a woman to pray to God with her head
uncovered? 14Does not nature itself teach you that for a man to wear long
hair is degrading to him, 15but if a woman has long hair, it is her pride? For
her hair is given to her for a covering. 16If any one is disposed to be
contentious, we recognize no other practice, nor do the churches of God.

Abuses at the Lord's Supper

17 But in the following instructions I do not commend you, because when
you come together it is not for the better but for the worse. 18For, in the first
place, when you assemble as a Church, I hear that there are divisions among
you; and I partly believe it, 19for there must be factions among you in order
that those who are genuine among you may be recognized. 20When you
meet together, it is not the Lord's supper that you eat. * 21For in eating, each
one goes ahead with his own meal, and one is hungry and another is drunk.
22What! Do you not have houses to eat and drink in? Or do you despise the
Church of God and humiliate those who have nothing? What shall I say to
you? Shall I commend you in this? No, I will not.

The Institution of the Eucharist

23 For I received from the Lord what I also delivered to you, that the Lord
Jesus on the night when he was betrayed took bread, 24and when he had
given thanks, he broke it, and said, "This is my body which is for[s] you. Do

this in remembrance of me.” [25]In the same way also the chalice, after supper, saying, “This chalice is the new covenant in my blood. Do this, as often as you drink it, in remembrance of me.” [26]For as often as you eat this bread and drink the chalice, you proclaim the Lord’s death until he comes.

Partaking of the Eucharist Unworthily

27 Whoever, therefore, eats the bread or drinks the cup of the Lord in an unworthy manner will be guilty of profaning the body and blood of the Lord. **28**Let a man examine himself, and so eat of the bread and drink of the cup. **29**For any one who eats and drinks without discerning the body eats and drinks judgment upon himself. **30**That is why many of you are weak and ill, and some have died.[t] **31**But if we judged ourselves truly, we should not be judged. [32]But when we are judged by the Lord, we are chastened[u] so that we may not be condemned along with the world.

33 So then, my brethren, when you come together to eat, wait for one another—[34]if any one is hungry, let him eat at home—lest you come together to be condemned. About the other things I will give directions when I come.

Spiritual Gifts

12 Now concerning spiritual gifts, brethren, I do not want you to be uninformed. [*] [2]You know that when you were heathen, you were led astray to mute idols, however you may have been moved. [3]Therefore I want you to understand that no one speaking by the Spirit of God ever says “Jesus be cursed!” and no one can say “Jesus is Lord” except by the Holy Spirit.

4 Now there are varieties of gifts, but the same Spirit; **5**and there are varieties of service, but the same Lord; **6**and there are varieties of working, but it is the same God who inspires them all in every one. **7**To each is given the manifestation of the Spirit for the common good. **8**To one is given through the Spirit the utterance of wisdom, and to another the utterance of knowledge according to the same Spirit, **9**to another faith by the same Spirit, to another gifts of healing by the one Spirit, [10]to another the working of miracles, to another prophecy, to another the ability to distinguish between spirits, to another various kinds of tongues, to another the interpretation of tongues. **11**All these are inspired by one and the same Spirit, who apportions to each one individually as he wills.

One Body with Many Members

12 For just as the body is one and has many members, and all the members of the body, though many, are one body, so it is with Christ. 13For by one Spirit we were all baptized into one body—Jews or Greeks, slaves or free—and all were made to drink of one Spirit.

14 For the body does not consist of one member but of many. **15**If the foot should say, “Because I am not a hand, I do not belong to the body,” that would not make it any less a part of the body. **16**And if the ear should say, “Because I am not an eye, I do not belong to the body,” that would not make it any less a part of the body. **17**If the whole body were an eye, where would be the hearing? If the whole body were an ear, where would be the sense of smell? **18**But as it is, God arranged the organs in the body, each one of them, as he chose. **19**If all were a single organ, where would the body be? **20**As it is, there are many parts, yet one body. **21**The eye cannot say to the hand, “I have no need of you,” nor again the head to the feet, “I have no need of you.” **22**On the contrary, the parts of the body which seem to be weaker are indispensable, **23**and those parts of the body which we think less honorable we invest with the greater honor, and our unpresentable parts are treated with greater modesty, **24**which our more presentable parts do not require. But God has so composed the body, giving the greater honor to the inferior part, **25**that there may be no discord in the body, but that the members may have the same care for one another. **26**If one member suffers, all suffer together; if one member is honored, all rejoice together.

27 Now you are the body of Christ and individually members of it. **28**And God has appointed in the Church first apostles, second prophets, third teachers, then workers of miracles, then healers, helpers, administrators, speakers in various kinds of tongues. **29**Are all apostles? Are all prophets? Are all teachers? Do all work miracles? **30**Do all possess gifts of healing? Do all speak with tongues? Do all interpret? **31**But earnestly desire the higher gifts.

And I will show you a still more excellent way. *

The Way of Love

13 If I speak in the tongues of men and of angels, but have not love, I am a noisy gong or a clanging cymbal. 2And if I have prophetic powers, and understand all mysteries and all knowledge, and if I have all faith, so as to remove mountains, but have not love, I am nothing. **3**If I give away all I

have, and if I deliver my body to be burned,[v] but have not love, I gain nothing.

4 Love is patient and kind; love is not jealous or boastful; [5]it is not arrogant or rude. Love does not insist on its own way; it is not irritable or resentful; [6]it does not rejoice at wrong, but rejoices in the right. [7]Love bears all things, believes all things, hopes all things, endures all things.

8 Love never ends; as for prophecies, they will pass away; as for tongues, they will cease; as for knowledge, it will pass away. [9]For our knowledge is imperfect and our prophecy is imperfect; [10]but when the perfect comes, the imperfect will pass away. [11]When I was a child, I spoke like a child, I thought like a child, I reasoned like a child; when I became a man, I gave up childish ways. [12]For now we see in a mirror dimly, but then face to face. Now I know in part; then I shall understand fully, even as I have been fully understood. [13]So faith, hope, love abide, these three; but the greatest of these is love.

Gifts of Prophecy and Tongues

14 Make love your aim, and earnestly desire the spiritual gifts, especially that you may prophesy. [2]For one who speaks in a tongue speaks not to men but to God; for no one understands him, but he utters mysteries in the Spirit. [3]On the other hand, he who prophesies speaks to men for their upbuilding and encouragement and consolation. [4]He who speaks in a tongue edifies himself, but he who prophesies edifies the Church. [5]Now I want you all to speak in tongues, but even more to prophesy. He who prophesies is greater than he who speaks in tongues, unless some one interprets, so that the Church may be edified.

6 Now, brethren, if I come to you speaking in tongues, how shall I benefit you unless I bring you some revelation or knowledge or prophecy or teaching? [7]If even lifeless instruments, such as the flute or the harp, do not give distinct notes, how will any one know what is played? [8]And if the bugle gives an indistinct sound, who will get ready for battle? [9]So with yourselves; if you in a tongue utter speech that is not intelligible, how will any one know what is said? For you will be speaking into the air. [10]There are doubtless many different languages in the world, and none is without meaning; [11]but if I do not know the meaning of the language, I shall be a foreigner to the speaker and the speaker a foreigner to me. [12]So with

yourselves; since you are eager for manifestations of the Spirit, strive to excel in building up the Church.

13 Therefore, he who speaks in a tongue should pray for the power to interpret. **14**For if I pray in a tongue, my spirit prays but my mind is unfruitful. **15**What am I to do? I will pray with the spirit and I will pray with the mind also; I will sing with the spirit and I will sing with the mind also. **16**Otherwise, if you bless[w] with the spirit, how can any one in the position of an outsider[x] say the "Amen" to your thanksgiving when he does not know what you are saying? **17**For you may give thanks well enough, but the other man is not edified. **18**I thank God that I speak in tongues more than you all; **19**nevertheless, in church I would rather speak five words with my mind, in order to instruct others, than ten thousand words in a tongue.

20 Brethren, do not be children in your thinking; be infants in evil, but in thinking be mature. **21**In the law it is written, "By men of strange tongues and by the lips of foreigners will I speak to this people, and even then they will not listen to me, says the Lord." **22**Thus, tongues are a sign not for believers but for unbelievers, while prophecy is not for unbelievers but for believers. **23**If, therefore, the whole Church assembles and all speak in tongues, and outsiders or unbelievers enter, will they not say that you are mad? **24**But if all prophesy, and an unbeliever or outsider enters, he is convicted by all, he is called to account by all, **25**the secrets of his heart are disclosed; and so, falling on his face, he will worship God and declare that God is really among you.

Orderly Worship

26 What then, brethren? When you come together, each one has a hymn, a lesson, a revelation, a tongue, or an interpretation. Let all things be done for edification. **27**If any speak in a tongue, let there be only two or at most three, and each in turn; and let one interpret. **28**But if there is no one to interpret, let each of them keep silence in church and speak to himself and to God. **29**Let two or three prophets speak, and let the others weigh what is said. **30**If a revelation is made to another sitting by, let the first be silent. **31**For you can all prophesy one by one, so that all may learn and all be encouraged; **32**and the spirits of prophets are subject to prophets. **33**For God is not a God of confusion but of peace.

As in all the churches of the saints, [34]the women should keep silence in the churches. For they are not permitted to speak, but should be subordinate, as even the law says. [35]If there is anything they desire to know, let them ask their husbands at home. For it is shameful for a woman to speak in church. [36]What! Did the word of God originate with you, or are you the only ones it has reached?

37 If any one thinks that he is a prophet, or spiritual, he should acknowledge that what I am writing to you is a command of the Lord. [38]If any one does not recognize this, he is not recognized. [39]So, my brethren, earnestly desire to prophesy, and do not forbid speaking in tongues; [40]but all things should be done decently and in order.

The Resurrection of Christ

15 Now I would remind you, brethren, in what terms I preached to you the gospel, which you received, in which you stand, [2]by which you are saved, if you hold it fast—unless you believed in vain.

[3] For I delivered to you as of first importance what I also received, that Christ died for our sins in accordance with the Scriptures, [4]that he was buried, that he was raised on the third day in accordance with the Scriptures, [5]and that he appeared to Ce'phas, then to the Twelve. [6]Then he appeared to more than five hundred brethren at one time, most of whom are still alive, though some have fallen asleep. [7]Then he appeared to James, then to all the apostles. [8]Last of all, as to one untimely born, he appeared also to me. [9]For I am the least of the apostles, unfit to be called an apostle, because I persecuted the Church of God. [10]But by the grace of God I am what I am, and his grace toward me was not in vain. On the contrary, I worked harder than any of them, though it was not I, but the grace of God which is with me. [11]Whether then it was I or they, so we preach and so you believed.

The Resurrection of the Dead

12 Now if Christ is preached as raised from the dead, how can some of you say that there is no resurrection of the dead? [13]But if there is no resurrection of the dead, then Christ has not been raised; * [14]if Christ has not been raised, then our preaching is in vain and your faith is in vain. [15]We are even found to be misrepresenting God, because we testified of God that he raised Christ, whom he did not raise if it is true that the dead are not

raised. 16For if the dead are not raised, then Christ has not been raised. 17If Christ has not been raised, your faith is futile and you are still in your sins. 18Then those also who have fallen asleep in Christ have perished. 19If for this life only we have hoped in Christ, we are of all men most to be pitied.

20 But in fact Christ has been raised from the dead, the first fruits of those who have fallen asleep. 21For as by a man came death, by a man has come also the resurrection of the dead. 22For as in Adam all die, so also in Christ shall all be made alive. 23But each in his own order: Christ the first fruits, then at his coming those who belong to Christ. 24Then comes the end, when he delivers the kingdom to God the Father after destroying every rule and every authority and power. 25For he must reign until he has put all his enemies under his feet. 26The last enemy to be destroyed is death. 27"For God[z] has put all things in subjection under his feet." But when it says, "All things are put in subjection under him," it is plain that he is excepted who put all things under him. 28When all things are subjected to him, then the Son himself will also be subjected to him who put all things under him, that God may be everything to every one.

29 Otherwise, what do people mean by being baptized on behalf of the dead? If the dead are not raised at all, why are people baptized on their behalf? * 30Why am I in peril every hour? 31I protest, brethren, by my pride in you which I have in Christ Jesus our Lord, I die every day! 32What do I gain if, humanly speaking, I fought with beasts at Ephesus? If the dead are not raised, "Let us eat and drink, for tomorrow we die." 33Do not be deceived: "Bad company ruins good morals." 34Come to your right mind, and sin no more. For some have no knowledge of God. I say this to your shame.

The Resurrection of the Body

35 But some one will ask, "How are the dead raised? With what kind of body do they come?" 36You foolish man! What you sow does not come to life unless it dies. 37And what you sow is not the body which is to be, but a bare kernel, perhaps of wheat or of some other grain. 38But God gives it a body as he has chosen, and to each kind of seed its own body. 39For not all flesh is alike, but there is one kind for men, another for animals, another for birds, and another for fish. 40There are celestial bodies and there are terrestrial bodies; but the glory of the celestial is one, and the glory of the

terrestrial is another. [41]There is one glory of the sun, and another glory of
the moon, and another glory of the stars; for star differs from star in glory.
42 So is it with the resurrection of the dead. What is sown is perishable,
what is raised is imperishable. [43]It is sown in dishonor, it is raised in glory.
It is sown in weakness, it is raised in power. [44]It is sown a physical body, it
is raised a spiritual body. If there is a physical body, there is also a spiritual
body. 45Thus it is written, "The first man Adam became a living soul"; the
last Adam became a life-giving spirit. [46]But it is not the spiritual which is
first but the physical, and then the spiritual. [47]The first man was from the
earth, a man of dust; the second man is from heaven. [48]As was the man of
dust, so are those who are of the dust; and as is the man of heaven, so are
those who are of heaven. [49]Just as we have borne the image of the man of
dust, we shall[a] also bear the image of the man of heaven. [50]I tell you this,
brethren: flesh and blood cannot inherit the kingdom of God, nor does the
perishable inherit the imperishable.
51 Behold! I tell you a mystery. We shall not all sleep, but we shall all be
changed, [52]in a moment, in the twinkling of an eye, at the last trumpet. For
the trumpet will sound, and the dead will be raised imperishable, and we
shall be changed. [53]For this perishable nature must put on the imperishable,
and this mortal nature must put on immortality. 54When the perishable puts
on the imperishable, and the mortal puts on immortality, then shall come to
pass the saying that is written:

"Death is swallowed up in victory."
55"O death, where is your victory?
O death, where is your sting?"

[56]The sting of death is sin, and the power of sin is the law. [57]But thanks be
to God, who gives us the victory through our Lord Jesus Christ.
58 Therefore, my beloved brethren, be steadfast, immovable, always
abounding in the work of the Lord, knowing that in the Lord your labor is
not in vain.

The Contribution for the Saints

16 Now concerning the contribution for the saints: * as I directed the
churches of Galatia, so you also are to do. 2On the first day of every week,
each of you is to put something aside and store it up, as he may prosper, so
that contributions need not be made when I come. 3And when I arrive, I will

send those whom you accredit by letter to carry your gift to Jerusalem. 4If it seems advisable that I should go also, they will accompany me.

Plans for Travel

5 I will visit you after passing through Macedonia, for I intend to pass through Macedonia, 6and perhaps I will stay with you or even spend the winter, so that you may speed me on my journey, wherever I go. 7For I do not want to see you now just in passing; I hope to spend some time with you, if the Lord permits. 8But I will stay in Ephesus until Pentecost, 9for a wide door for effective work has opened to me, and there are many adversaries.

10 When Timothy comes, see that you put him at ease among you, for he is doing the work of the Lord, as I am. 11So let no one despise him. Speed him on his way in peace, that he may return to me; for I am expecting him with the brethren.

12 As for our brother Apol'los, I strongly urged him to visit you with the other brethren, but it was not at all his will[b] to come now. He will come when he has opportunity.

Final Message and Greeting

13 Be watchful, stand firm in your faith, be courageous, be strong. 14Let all that you do be done in love.

15 Now, brethren, you know that the household of Steph'anas were the first converts in Acha'ia, and they have devoted themselves to the service of the saints; 16I urge you to be subject to such men and to every fellow worker and laborer. 17I rejoice at the coming of Steph'anas and Fortuna'tus and Acha'icus, because they have made up for your absence; 18for they refreshed my spirit as well as yours. Give recognition to such men.

19 The churches of Asia send greetings. Aqui'la and Prisca, together with the church in their house, send you hearty greetings in the Lord. 20All the brethren send greetings. Greet one another with a holy kiss.

21 I, Paul, write this greeting with my own hand. 22If any one has no love for the Lord, let him be accursed. Our Lord, come![c] 1The grace of the Lord Jesus be with you. 24My love be with you all in Christ Jesus. Amen.

2 Corinthians

Chapters

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12 13

THE SECOND LETTER OF PAUL TO THE CORINTHIANS

Salutation

1 Paul, an apostle of Christ Jesus by the will of God, and Timothy our brother.

To the Church of God which is at Corinth, with all the saints who are in the whole of Acha'ia:

2 Grace to you and peace from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ.

Paul's Thanksgiving after Affliction

3 Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, the Father of mercies and God of all comfort, 4who comforts us in all our affliction, so that we may be able to comfort those who are in any affliction, with the comfort with which we ourselves are comforted by God. 5For as we share abundantly in Christ's sufferings, so through Christ we share abundantly in comfort too.[a] 6If we are afflicted, it is for your comfort and salvation; and if we are comforted, it is for your comfort, which you experience when you patiently endure the same sufferings that we suffer. 7Our hope for you is unshaken; for we know that as you share in our sufferings, you will also share in our comfort.

8 For we do not want you to be ignorant, brethren, of the affliction * we experienced in Asia; for we were so utterly, unbearably crushed that we despaired of life itself. 9Why, we felt that we had received the sentence of death; but that was to make us rely not on ourselves but on God who raises the dead; 10he delivered us from so deadly a peril, and he will deliver us; on him we have set our hope that he will deliver us again. 11You also must help us by prayer, so that many will give thanks on our behalf for the blessing granted us in answer to many prayers.

12 For our boast is this, the testimony of our conscience that we have behaved in the world, and still more toward you, with holiness and godly sincerity, not by earthly wisdom but by the grace of God. 13For we write you nothing but what you can read and understand; I hope you will understand fully, 14as you have understood in part, that you can be proud of us as we can be of you, on the day of the Lord Jesus.

The Postponement of Paul's Visit

15 Because I was sure of this, I wanted to come to you first, so that you might have a double pleasure;[b] 16I wanted to visit you on my way to Macedonia, and to come back to you from Macedonia and have you send

me on my way to Judea. [17]Was I vacillating when I wanted to do this? Do I make my plans like a worldly man, ready to say Yes and No at once? [18]As surely as God is faithful, our word to you has not been Yes and No. [19]For the Son of God, Jesus Christ, whom we preached among you, Silva'nus and Timothy and I, was not Yes and No; but in him it is always Yes. [20]For all the promises of God find their Yes in him. That is why we utter the Amen through him, to the glory of God. [21]But it is God who establishes us with you in Christ, and has commissioned us; [22]he has put his seal upon us and given us his Spirit in our hearts as a guarantee.

23 But I call God to witness against me—it was to spare you that I refrained from coming to Corinth. [24]Not that we lord it over your faith; we work with you for your joy, for you stand firm in

2 your faith. [1]For I made up my mind not to make you another painful visit. [2]For if I cause you pain, who is there to make me glad but the one whom I have pained? [3]And I wrote as I did, so that when I came I might not suffer pain from those who should have made me rejoice, for I felt sure of all of you, that my joy would be the joy of you all. [4]For I wrote you out of much affliction and anguish of heart and with many tears, not to cause you pain but to let you know the abundant love that I have for you.

Forgiveness for the Offender

5 But if any one has caused pain, he has caused it not to me, but in some measure—not to put it too severely—to you all. [6]For such a one this punishment by the majority is enough; [7]so you should rather turn to forgive and comfort him, or he may be overwhelmed by excessive sorrow. [8]So I beg you to reaffirm your love for him. [9]For this is why I wrote, that I might test you and know whether you are obedient in everything. [10]Any one whom you forgive, I also forgive. What I have forgiven, if I have forgiven anything, has been for your sake in the presence of Christ, [11]to keep Satan from gaining the advantage over us; for we are not ignorant of his designs.

Paul's Anxiety in Troas

12 When I came to Troas to preach the gospel of Christ, a door was opened for me in the Lord; [13]but my mind could not rest because I did not find my brother Titus there. So I took leave of them and went on to Macedonia.

14 But thanks be to God, who in Christ always leads us in triumph, and through us spreads the fragrance of the knowledge of him everywhere. **15**For we are the aroma of Christ to God among those who are being saved and among those who are perishing, **16**to one a fragrance from death to death, to the other a fragrance from life to life. Who is sufficient for these things? **17**For we are not, like so many, peddlers of God's word; but as men of sincerity, as commissioned by God, in the sight of God we speak in Christ.

Ministers of the New Covenant

3 Are we beginning to commend ourselves again? Or do we need, as some do, letters of recommendation to you, or from you? **2**You yourselves are our letter of recommendation, written on your[c] hearts, to be known and read by all men; **3**and you show that you are a letter from Christ delivered by us, written not with ink but with the Spirit of the living God, not on tablets of stone but on tablets of human hearts.

4 Such is the confidence that we have through Christ toward God. **5**Not that we are sufficient of ourselves to claim anything as coming from us; our sufficiency is from God, **6**who has qualified us to be ministers of a new covenant, not in a written code but in the Spirit; for the written code kills, but the Spirit gives life.

7 Now if the dispensation of death, carved in letters on stone, came with such splendor that the Israelites could not look at Moses' face because of its brightness, fading as this was, **8**will not the dispensation of the Spirit be attended with greater splendor? **9**For if there was splendor in the dispensation of condemnation, the dispensation of righteousness must far exceed it in splendor. **10**Indeed, in this case, what once had splendor has come to have no splendor at all, because of the splendor that surpasses it. **11**For if what faded away came with splendor, what is permanent must have much more splendor.

12 Since we have such a hope, we are very bold, **13**not like Moses, who put a veil over his face so that the Israelites might not see the end of the fading splendor. **14**But their minds were hardened; for to this day, when they read the old covenant, that same veil remains unlifted, because only through Christ is it taken away. **15**Yes, to this day whenever Moses is read a veil lies over their minds; **16**but when a man turns to the Lord the veil is removed.

17 Now the Lord is the Spirit, and where the Spirit of the Lord is, there is
freedom. 18 And we all, with unveiled face, beholding[d] the glory of the
Lord, are being changed into his likeness from one degree of glory to
another; for this comes from the Lord who is the Spirit. *

4 Therefore, having this ministry by the mercy of God,[e] we do not lose
heart. 2 We have renounced disgraceful, underhanded ways; we refuse to
practice cunning or to tamper with God's word, but by the open statement
of the truth we would commend ourselves to every man's conscience in the
sight of God. 3 And even if our gospel is veiled, it is veiled only to those
who are perishing. 4 In their case the god of this world has blinded the minds
of the unbelievers, to keep them from seeing the light of the gospel of the
glory of Christ, who is the likeness of God. 5 For what we preach is not
ourselves, but Jesus Christ as Lord, with ourselves as your servants[f] for
Jesus' sake. 6 For it is the God who said, "Let light shine out of darkness,"
who has shone in our hearts to give the light of the knowledge of the glory
of God in the face of Christ.

Treasure in Earthen Vessels

7 But we have this treasure * in earthen vessels, to show that the
transcendent power belongs to God and not to us. 8 We are afflicted in every
way, but not crushed; perplexed, but not driven to despair; 9 persecuted, but
not forsaken; struck down, but not destroyed; 10 always carrying in the body
the death of Jesus, so that the life of Jesus may also be manifested in our
bodies. 11 For while we live we are always being given up to death for Jesus'
sake, so that the life of Jesus may be manifested in our mortal flesh. 12 So
death is at work in us, but life in you. *

13 Since we have the same spirit of faith as he had who wrote, "I believed,
and so I spoke," we too believe, and so we speak, 14 knowing that he who
raised the Lord Jesus will raise us also with Jesus and bring us with you into
his presence. 15 For it is all for your sake, so that as grace extends to more
and more people it may increase thanksgiving, to the glory of God.

Living by Faith

16 So we do not lose heart. Though our outer man is wasting away, our
inner man is being renewed every day. 17 For this slight momentary
affliction is preparing for us an eternal weight of glory beyond all
comparison, 18 because we look not to the things that are seen but to the

things that are unseen; for the things that are seen are transient, but the things that are unseen are eternal.

5 For we know that if the earthly tent we live in is destroyed, we have a building from God, a house not made with hands, eternal in the heavens. 2Here indeed we groan, and long to put on our heavenly dwelling, 3so that by putting it on we may not be found naked. 4For while we are still in this tent, we sigh with anxiety; not that we would be unclothed, but that we would be further clothed, so that what is mortal may be swallowed up by life. 5He who has prepared us for this very thing is God, who has given us the Spirit as a guarantee.

6 So we are always of good courage; we know that while we are at home in the body we are away from the Lord, 7for we walk by faith, not by sight. 8We are of good courage, and we would rather be away from the body and at home with the Lord. 9So whether we are at home or away, we make it our aim to please him. 10For we must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ, so that each one may receive good or evil, according to what he has done in the body.

The Ministry of Reconciliation

11 Therefore, knowing the fear of the Lord, we persuade men; but what we are is known to God, and I hope it is known also to your conscience. 12We are not commending ourselves to you again but giving you cause to be proud of us, so that you may be able to answer those who pride themselves on a man's position and not on his heart. 13For if we are beside ourselves, it is for God; if we are in our right mind, it is for you. 14For the love of Christ urges us on, because we are convinced that one has died for all; therefore all have died. 15And he died for all, that those who live might live no longer for themselves but for him who for their sake died and was raised.

16 From now on, therefore, we regard no one according to the flesh; even though we once regarded Christ according to the flesh, we regard him thus no longer. 17Therefore, if any one is in Christ, he is a new creation;[g] the old has passed away, behold, the new has come. 18All this is from God, who through Christ reconciled us to himself and gave us the ministry of reconciliation; 19that is, in Christ God was reconciling[h] the world to himself, * not counting their trespasses against them, and entrusting to us the message of reconciliation. 20So we are ambassadors for Christ, God

making his appeal through us. We beg you on behalf of Christ, be reconciled to God. 21For our sake he made him to be sin * who knew no sin, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God.

6 Working together with him, then, we entreat you not to accept the grace of God in vain. 2For he says,

"At the acceptable time I have listened to you,
and helped you on the day of salvation."

Behold, now is the acceptable time; behold, now is the day of salvation. 3We put no obstacle in any one's way, so that no fault may be found with our ministry, 4but as servants of God we commend ourselves in every way: through great endurance, in afflictions, hardships, calamities, 5beatings, imprisonments, tumults, labors, watching, hunger; 6by purity, knowledge, forbearance, kindness, the Holy Spirit, genuine love, 7truthful speech, and the power of God; with the weapons of righteousness for the right hand and for the left; 8in honor and dishonor, in ill repute and good repute. We are treated as impostors, and yet are true; 9as unknown, and yet well known; as dying, and behold we live; as punished, and yet not killed; 10as sorrowful, yet always rejoicing; as poor, yet making many rich; as having nothing, and yet possessing everything.

11 Our mouth is open to you, Corinthians; our heart is wide. 12You are not restricted by us, but you are restricted in your own affections. 13In return—I speak as to children—widen your hearts also.

The Temple of the Living God

14 Do not be mismated with unbelievers. For what partnership have righteousness and iniquity? Or what fellowship has light with darkness? 15What accord has Christ with Be'lial?[i] Or what has a believer in common with an unbeliever? 16What agreement has the temple of God with idols? For we are the temple of the living God; as God said,

"I will live in them and move among them,
and I will be their God,
and they shall be my people.
17Therefore come out from them,
and be separate from them, says the Lord,
and touch nothing unclean;
then I will welcome you,

[18]and I will be a father to you,
and you shall be my sons and daughters,
says the Lord Almighty.”

7 Since we have these promises, beloved, let us cleanse ourselves from every defilement of body and spirit, and make holiness perfect in the fear of God.

Paul’s Joy at the Corinthians’Repentance and Zeal

[2] Open your hearts to us; we have wronged no one, we have corrupted no one, we have taken advantage of no one. [3]I do not say this to condemn you, for I said before that you are in our hearts, to die together and to live together. [4]I have great confidence in you; I have great pride in you; I am filled with comfort. With all our affliction, I am overjoyed.

[5] For even when we came into Macedonia, our bodies had no rest but we were afflicted at every turn—fighting without and fear within. [6]But God, who comforts the downcast, comforted us by the coming of Titus, [7]and not only by his coming but also by the comfort with which he was comforted in you, as he told us of your longing, your mourning, your zeal for me, so that I rejoiced still more. [8]For even if I made you sorry with my letter, I do not regret it (though I did regret it), for I see that that letter grieved you, though only for a while. [9]As it is, I rejoice, not because you were grieved, but because you were grieved into repenting; for you felt a godly grief, so that you suffered no loss through us. [10]For godly grief produces a repentance that leads to salvation and brings no regret, but worldly grief produces death. [11]For see what earnestness this godly grief has produced in you, what eagerness to clear yourselves, what indignation, what alarm, what longing, what zeal, what punishment! At every point you have proved yourselves guiltless in the matter. [12]So although I wrote to you, it was not on account of the one who did the wrong, nor on account of the one who suffered the wrong, but in order that your zeal for us might be revealed to you in the sight of God. [13]Therefore we are comforted.

And besides our own comfort we rejoiced still more at the joy of Titus, because his mind has been set at rest by you all. [14]For if I have expressed to him some pride in you, I was not put to shame; but just as everything we said to you was true, so our boasting before Titus has proved true. [15]And his heart goes out all the more to you, as he remembers the obedience of you

all, and the fear and trembling with which you received him. [16]I rejoice, because I have perfect confidence in you.

Encouragement to Be Generous

8 We want you to know, brethren, about the grace of God which has been shown in the churches of Macedonia, [2]for in a severe test of affliction, their abundance of joy and their extreme poverty have overflowed in a wealth of liberality on their part. [3]For they gave according to their means, as I can testify, and beyond their means, of their own free will, [4]begging us earnestly for the favor of taking part in the relief of the saints—[5]and this, not as we expected, but first they gave themselves to the Lord and to us by the will of God. [6]Accordingly we have urged Titus that as he had already made a beginning, he should also complete among you this gracious work. [7]Now as you excel in everything—in faith, in utterance, in knowledge, in all earnestness, and in your love for us—see that you excel in this gracious work also.

8 I say this not as a command, but to prove by the earnestness of others that your love also is genuine. [9]For you know the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ, that though he was rich, yet for your sake he became poor, so that by his poverty you might become rich. [10]And in this matter I give my advice: it is best for you now to complete what a year ago you began not only to do but to desire, [11]so that your readiness in desiring it may be matched by your completing it out of what you have. [12]For if the readiness is there, it is acceptable according to what a man has, not according to what he has not. [13]I do not mean that others should be eased and you burdened, [14]but that as a matter of equality your abundance at the present time should supply their want, so that their abundance may supply your want, that there may be equality. [15]As it is written, “He who gathered much had nothing over, and he who gathered little had no lack.”

Commendation of Titus

16 But thanks be to God who puts the same earnest care for you into the heart of Titus. [17]For he not only accepted our appeal, but being himself very earnest he is going to you of his own accord. [18]With him we are sending the brother who is famous among all the churches for his preaching of the gospel; [19]and not only that, but he has been appointed by the churches to travel with us in this gracious work which we are carrying on, for the glory

of the Lord and to show our good will. 20We intend that no one should blame us about this liberal gift which we are administering, 21for we aim at what is honorable not only in the Lord's sight but also in the sight of men. 22And with them we are sending our brother whom we have often tested and found earnest in many matters, but who is now more earnest than ever because of his great confidence in you. 23As for Titus, he is my partner and fellow worker in your service; and as for our brethren, they are messengers[j] of the churches, the glory of Christ. 24So give proof, before the churches, of your love and of our boasting about you to these men.

Generosity in Giving

9 Now it is superfluous * for me to write to you about the offering for the saints, 2for I know your readiness, of which I boast about you to the people of Macedonia, saying that Acha'ia has been ready since last year; and your zeal has stirred up most of them. 3But I am sending the brethren so that our boasting about you may not prove vain in this case, so that you may be ready, as I said you would be; 4lest if some Macedonians come with me and find that you are not ready, we be humiliated—to say nothing of you—for being so confident. 5So I thought it necessary to urge the brethren to go on to you before me, and arrange in advance for this gift you have promised, so that it may be ready not as an exaction but as a willing gift.

6 The point is this: he who sows sparingly will also reap sparingly, and he who sows bountifully will also reap bountifully. 7Each one must do as he has made up his mind, not reluctantly or under compulsion, for God loves a cheerful giver. 8And God is able to provide you with every blessing in abundance, so that you may always have enough of everything and may provide in abundance for every good work. 9As it is written,

> "He scatters abroad, he gives to the poor;
> his righteousness[k] endures for ever."

10He who supplies seed to the sower and bread for food will supply and multiply your resources[l] and increase the harvest of your righteousness.[k] 11You will be enriched in every way for great generosity, which through us will produce thanksgiving to God; 12for the rendering of this service not only supplies the wants of the saints but also overflows in many thanksgivings to God. 13Under the test of this service, you[m] will glorify God by your obedience in acknowledging the gospel of Christ, and by the

generosity of your contribution for them and for all others; [14]while they long for you and pray for you, because of the surpassing grace of God in you. [15]Thanks be to God for his inexpressible gift!

Paul Defends His Ministry

10 I, Paul, myself entreat you, by the meekness and gentleness of Christ —I who am humble when face to face with you, but bold to you when I am away! [*]—[2]I beg of you that when I am present I may not have to show boldness with such confidence as I count on showing against some who suspect us of acting in worldly fashion. [3]For though we live in the world we are not carrying on a worldly war, [4]for the weapons of our warfare are not worldly but have divine power to destroy strongholds. [5]We destroy arguments and every proud obstacle to the knowledge of God, and take every thought captive to obey Christ, [6]being ready to punish every disobedience, when your obedience is complete.

7 Look at what is before your eyes. If any one is confident that he is Christ's, let him remind himself that as he is Christ's, so are we. [8]For even if I boast a little too much of our authority, which the Lord gave for building you up and not for destroying you, I shall not be put to shame. [9]I would not seem to be frightening you with letters. For they say, "His letters are weighty and strong, but his bodily presence is weak, and his speech of no account." [11]Let such people understand that what we say by letter when absent, we do when present. [12]Not that we venture to class or compare ourselves with some of those who commend themselves. But when they measure themselves by one another, and compare themselves with one another, they are without understanding.

13 But we will not boast beyond limit, but will keep to the limits God has apportioned us, to reach even to you. [14]For we are not overextending ourselves, as though we did not reach you; we were the first to come all the way to you with the gospel of Christ. [15]We do not boast beyond limit, in other men's labors; but our hope is that as your faith increases, our field among you may be greatly enlarged, [16]so that we may preach the gospel in lands beyond you, without boasting of work already done in another's field. [17]"Let him who boasts, boast of the Lord." [18]For it is not the man who commends himself that is accepted, but the man whom the Lord commends.

Paul and the False Apostles

11 I wish you would bear with me in a little foolishness. Do bear with
me! 2I feel a divine jealousy for you, for I betrothed you to Christ to present
you as a pure bride to her one husband. 3But I am afraid that as the serpent
deceived Eve by his cunning, your thoughts will be led astray from a
sincere and pure devotion to Christ. 4For if some one comes and preaches
another Jesus than the one we preached, or if you receive a different spirit
from the one you received, or if you accept a different gospel from the one
you accepted, you submit to it readily enough. 5I think that I am not in the
least inferior to these superlative apostles. 6Even if I am unskilled in
speaking, I am not in knowledge; in every way we have made this plain to
you in all things.

7 Did I commit a sin in abasing myself so that you might be exalted,
because I preached God's gospel without cost to you? 8I robbed other
churches by accepting support from them in order to serve you. 9And when
I was with you and was in want, I did not burden any one, for my needs
were supplied by the brethren who came from Macedonia. So I refrained
and will refrain from burdening you in any way. 10As the truth of Christ is
in me, this boast of mine shall not be silenced in the regions of Acha'ia.
11And why? Because I do not love you? God knows I do!

12 And what I do I will continue to do, in order to undermine the claim of
those who would like to claim that in their boasted mission they work on
the same terms as we do. 13For such men are false apostles, deceitful
workmen, disguising themselves as apostles of Christ. 14And no wonder, for
even Satan disguises himself as an angel of light. 15So it is not strange if his
servants also disguise themselves as servants of righteousness. Their end
will correspond to their deeds.

Paul's Sufferings as an Apostle

16 I repeat, let no one think me foolish; but even if you do, accept me as a
fool, so that I too may boast a little. 17(What I am saying I say not with the
Lord's authority but as a fool, in this boastful confidence; 18since many
boast of worldly things, I too will boast.) 19For you gladly bear with fools,
being wise yourselves! 20For you bear it if a man makes slaves of you, or
preys upon you, or takes advantage of you, or puts on airs, or strikes you in
the face. 21To my shame, I must say, we were too weak for that!

But whatever any one dares to boast of—I am speaking as a fool—I also dare to boast of that. 22Are they Hebrews? So am I. Are they Israelites? So am I. Are they descendants of Abraham? So am I. 23Are they servants of Christ? I am a better one—I am talking like a madman—with far greater labors, far more imprisonments, with countless beatings, and often near death. 24Five times I have received at the hands of the Jews the forty lashes less one. 25Three times I have been beaten with rods; once I was stoned. Three times I have been shipwrecked; a night and a day I have been adrift at sea; 26on frequent journeys, in danger from rivers, danger from robbers, danger from my own people, danger from Gentiles, danger in the city, danger in the wilderness, danger at sea, danger from false brethren; 27in toil and hardship, through many a sleepless night, in hunger and thirst, often without food, in cold and exposure. 28And, apart from other things, there is the daily pressure upon me of my anxiety for all the churches. 29Who is weak, and I am not weak? Who is made to fall, and I am not indignant?

30 If I must boast, I will boast of the things that show my weakness. 31The God and Father of the Lord Jesus, he who is blessed for ever, knows that I do not lie. 32At Damascus, the governor under King Ar'etas guarded the city of Damascus in order to seize me, 33but I was let down in a basket through a window in the wall, and escaped his hands.

Paul's Visions and Revelations

12 I must boast; there is nothing to be gained by it, but I will go on to visions and revelations of the Lord. 2I know a man in Christ who fourteen years ago was caught up to the third heaven—whether in the body or out of the body I do not know, God knows. 3And I know that this man was caught up into Paradise—whether in the body or out of the body I do not know, God knows—4and he heard things that cannot be told, which man may not utter. 5On behalf of this man I will boast, but on my own behalf I will not boast, except of my weaknesses. 6Though if I wish to boast, I shall not be a fool, for I shall be speaking the truth. But I refrain from it, so that no one may think more of me than he sees in me or hears from me. 7And to keep me from being too elated by the abundance of revelations, a thorn * was given me in the flesh, a messenger of Satan, to harass me, to keep me from being too elated. 8Three times I begged the Lord about this, that it should leave me; 9but he said to me, "My grace is sufficient for you, for my power

is made perfect in weakness." I will all the more gladly boast of my weaknesses, that the power of Christ may rest upon me. 10For the sake of Christ, then, I am content with weaknesses, insults, hardships, persecutions, and calamities; for when I am weak, then I am strong.

Paul's Concern for the Corinthian Church

11 I have been a fool! You forced me to it, for I ought to have been commended by you. For I am not at all inferior to these superlative apostles, even though I am nothing. 12The signs of a true apostle were performed among you in all patience, with signs and wonders and mighty works. 13For in what were you less favored than the rest of the churches, except that I myself did not burden you? Forgive me this wrong! *

14 Here for the third time I am ready to come to you. And I will not be a burden, for I seek not what is yours but you; for children ought not to lay up for their parents, but parents for their children. 15I will most gladly spend and be spent for your souls. If I love you the more, am I to be loved the less? 16But granting that I myself did not burden you, I was crafty, you say, and got the better of you by guile. 17Did I take advantage of you through any of those whom I sent to you? 18I urged Titus to go, and sent the brother with him. Did Titus take advantage of you? Did we not act in the same spirit? Did we not take the same steps?

19 Have you been thinking all along that we have been defending ourselves before you? It is in the sight of God that we have been speaking in Christ, and all for your upbuilding, beloved. 20For I fear that perhaps I may come and find you not what I wish, and that you may find me not what you wish; that perhaps there may be quarreling, jealousy, anger, selfishness, slander, gossip, conceit, and disorder. 21I fear that when I come again my God may humble me before you, and I may have to mourn over many of those who sinned before and have not repented of the impurity, immorality, and licentiousness which they have practiced.

Further Warning

13 This is the third time I am coming to you. Any charge must be sustained by the evidence of two or three witnesses. 2I warned those who sinned before and all the others, and I warn them now while absent, as I did when present on my second visit, that if I come again I will not spare them —3since you desire proof that Christ is speaking in me. He is not weak in dealing with you, but is powerful in you. 4For he was crucified in weakness,

but lives by the power of God. For we are weak in him, but in dealing with you we shall live with him by the power of God.

5 Examine yourselves, to see whether you are holding to your faith. Test yourselves. Do you not realize that Jesus Christ is in you?—unless indeed you fail to meet the test! **6**I hope you will find out that we have not failed. **7**But we beg God that you may not do wrong—not that we may appear to have met the test, but that you may do what is right, though we may seem to have failed. **8**For we cannot do anything against the truth, but only for the truth. **9**For we are glad when we are weak and you are strong. What we pray for is your improvement. **10**I write this while I am away from you, in order that when I come I may not have to be severe in my use of the authority which the Lord has given me for building up and not for tearing down.

Final Greetings and Benediction

11 Finally, brethren, rejoice. Mend your ways, heed my appeal, agree with one another, live in peace, and the God of love and peace will be with you. **12**Greet one another with a holy kiss. **13**All the saints greet you.

14 The grace of the Lord Jesus Christ and the love of God and the fellowship of[n] the Holy Spirit be with you all.